PRACTITIONER REFERENCE

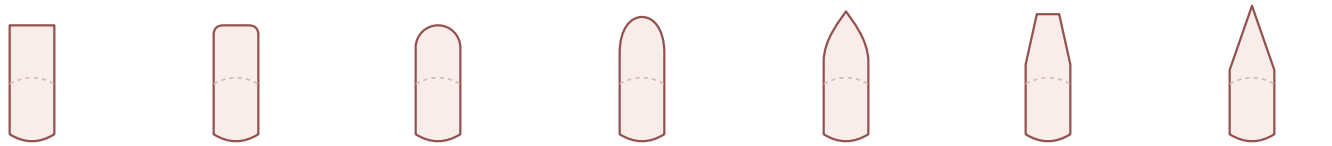
Nail Systems Cheat Sheet

Pick the right system, cure it fully, and keep product off the skin.

Systems compared

SYSTEM	SETS BY	WEAR	STRENGTH	REMOVAL	FILL / REDO	ALLERGY & SAFETY
Gel polish	LED/UV cure	[2–3] wk	Flexible; adds little strength	Soak-off	New set [2–3] wk	Methacrylates, often HEMA. Keep off skin.
Builder gel	LED/UV cure	[3–4] wk	Medium; some flex	Soak- or file-off	Infill [3–4] wk	Thick layers need the full cure time.
Hard gel	LED/UV cure	[3–4] wk	Strong; rigid	File-off only	Rebalance [3–4] wk	Heavy dust: use extraction and a mask.
Soft gel tips	LED/UV cure	[3–4] wk	Light; flexible	Soak-off	New set [3–4] wk	Gel adhesive is a methacrylate too.
Acrylic	Air-sets	[2–3] wk	Strongest; rigid	Acetone soak	Fill [2–3] wk	EMA liquid only, never MMA. Ventilate.
Dip powder	Activator	[3–4] wk	Strong; fairly rigid	File top, then soak	New set [3–4] wk	Cyanoacrylate. Single-use powder portions.

Nail shapes



Square — Wide, strong

Squoval — Soft corners

Round — Follows tip

Oval — Classic

Almond — Soft point

Coffin — Aka ballerina

Stiletto — Needs length

File grit guide

GRIT	TYPE	USE FOR
80–100	Coarse	Enhancements only: bulk removal and reshaping. Never the natural nail.
150–180	Medium	Refining enhancements; 180 for shaping a natural free edge.
180–240	Fine	Natural nail shaping and light shine removal before product.
240+	Extra fine, buffer	Smoothing, buffing and finishing. Don't overfile the plate.

LAMP & CURE

- **Match the lamp** to the gel brand.
- Thin coats; cure each for the full stated time.
- Check output; replace bulbs as the maker advises.
- Under-cured gel is the main allergy route.
- Offer SPF 30+ (20 min before) or UV gloves.

E-FILE BIT BASICS

- **Trained use only.** Low to moderate speed.
- Coarse bits: product only, never the plate.
- Keep the bit moving and flat; stop at any heat.
- Sanding bands are single-use.
- Clean, then disinfect bits after every client.

Every time. Follow every manufacturer's instructions; check gels are legal where you work (EU/UK: TPO-free).